

NEO ZHANG

SENIOR COMBAT & SYSTEMS DESIGNER

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SKILLS

Design: Combat Design, Systems Design, Encounter Design, Level Design, Enemy Design, Narrative Design, Cinematic Design, Technical Design, In-Engine Implementation, Prototyping, Game Balancing, Debugging & Bug Fixing

Engines: UE5, Unity, Godot

Programming & Scripting Languages: C#, C++, Python, UE5 Blueprint

Misc Tools: Miro, Visual Studio, Figma, Jira, Blender, Google Workspace, Microsoft Office, Git

Spoken Languages: English & Mandarin Chinese

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Combat & Systems Designer | Unity + Proprietary Tools | Jan 2026 – Present

Shadowstone – 3D Co-op Tactics RPG Roguelite | (PC Early Access)

- Defined, pitched, and implemented Shadowstone's core combat system and enemy/biome design ruleset, creating systemic interactions that generate fresh tactical situations every round and every run.
- Owned design of 30+ enemies and 5 boss encounters from concept to release in 4-week cycles, defining each mechanic's core visual cues and collaborating with Art, Animation, and VFX to bring them to life.
- Designed and implemented opt-in escalation systems where player choice, not skill, drives late-game difficulty, preserving the core loop while keeping new content relevant across runs.
- Shipped content and balance patches on a 4-week cadence driven by live telemetry and player feedback, increasing runs per player by up to 59% per release.
- Established a cross-discipline enemy production pipeline with Engineering, Art, UX, and QA, cutting hand-off clarification requests by 60%.

Level & Narrative Designer | Unity + Proprietary Tools | Oct 2023 – Jan 2026

Sunderfolk + DLC – 3D Co-op Tactics RPG | (PC / Xbox / PS5 / Switch)

- Designed co-op systems for a phone-as-controller, shared-screen format, making tactical play accessible to both core and casual players without sacrificing strategic depth.
- Partnered with the Game Director to design and implement DLC (worldbuilding, new hero, scope/budget), driving a 17% sales increase and doubling daily active players.
- Led design of 10 missions from paper concept and blockout through iteration and ship, each built around a distinct feature (puzzle, combat, exploration) that encourages cooperative strategy.
- Owned 10 characters end-to-end (1 playable hero, 4 bosses, 5 enemies), designing ability kits from each character's fantasy and balancing the hero against the full roster for co-op play.
- Co-led creative direction and implementation of 30+ cutscenes, from script and storyboard to in-engine assembly.
- Wrote and implemented 75% of the game's narrative content, including NPC dialogue, tutorials, and barks.

Design Officer, Designer, and Engineer @ UCSC's Game Design and Art | Unity + UE4 | Sep 2019 – Jul 2023

TacoCat (2023), Asterion (2022), Gremlin Garden (2021) – Playable 2D and 3D games | (PC)

- Mentored 35+ student designers over 2 years, running 10 workshops annually on design fundamentals, team workflow, and cross-discipline collaboration.
- Built UE4 and Unity editor tools (cutscene builder, ability creator, level editor) that let designers, artists, and writers create content independently, cutting creation time by an average of 68%.

EDUCATION

B.S. in Computer Science & Game Design | University of California, Santa Cruz | 2019 – 2023